

Solitary Confinement

UBC LAW 401D: Penal Policy

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This painting is an interpretation of some of the descriptions of solitary confinement found in Sector Four, chapters one and two of *Justice Behind the Walls*.¹ The white framed box that closes in the man is meant to signify the feeling of being closed in and claustrophobic. The borders are filled with some of the descriptive words found in quotations from *the Textbook*,² and from my conversations with inmates at Matsqui. The box itself is inside a vast dark space, which shows that while feeling closed in, the man also feels small and insignificant. The box is both real and figurative, symbolizing the actual walls of the cell, but also the mind of the man. He clutches his head in his hands to show the struggle with his own thoughts, and the fear of losing his mind. The red digital clock along the bottom shows zeros for the hours, minutes and seconds, to represent how time seems to stand still. The scratch marks on the wall are meant to show his hopeful attempt to record the days at first, followed by eventually giving up and using his own blood to draw in the last mark. This represents the futility of keeping track when the idea of a day has lost its meaning and there is no ability to predict release.

The brick wall between the cell and the outdoors is another layer of enclosure, but it shows how thin the barrier is between an environment of fear and suffering, and the freedom of the outside world. A thought I had while we were visiting Matsqui was that if small conditions were changed in any of our lives, it could be us there. I don't believe that most people who end up incarcerated are inherently "bad", I believe that all of us are products of our circumstances. To me, negatively judging someone who lacked the privileged circumstances that most of us have had in our lives is narrow-minded and

¹ Michael Jackson, *Justice Behind the Walls: Human Rights in Canadian Prisons* (Vancouver: Douglas & McIntyre, 2002) [*the Textbook*].

² *ibid*

entitled. I would hope that anyone who understood the conditions of solitary confinement would agree that no one should be subject to such treatment.

The roses growing along the brick wall are another symbol of how the prison walls block out the beauty of the outside world. The bright flowers mean that life exists and time passes outside the walls. At the same time, the encroaching leaves and thorns are creating another layer, a natural wall burying the people inside the prison. The thorns in the rose bush mimic barbed wire.

The colours in the painting are deliberate. The use of red is meant as a sharp contrast to the black and white. It should remind the viewer of blood, and how spilling blood (either from himself or from someone else) might be preferable to the endless hours spent alone. The man himself is done in negative imagery because he is a shadow of a person, drained of life and colour.

The image of a person sitting alone in solitary confinement struck me over and over throughout this course. Speaking with people at Matsqui, seeing the video of Ashley Smith, and reading the self-reports and poetry from prisoners, made me think of how it would feel to be stripped of all control over your life, given only the basic necessities to survive, and left almost completely alone for an indefinite amount of time. For me that would be worse than death. Removing stimulation and human interaction is a recipe[®] for mental illness in even the sanest person, and *is* torture. This painting is my attempt to capture and interpret these thoughts and emotions.